

Mohamed Afsal Pallikkara, CISSP

Senior Infrastructure & Cloud Leader · Head of Infrastructure · Cybersecurity Engineering
mafsal.p@gmail.com | +971 55 941 2326 | United Arab Emirates | [linkedin.com/in/afsalpallikkara](https://www.linkedin.com/in/afsalpallikkara)

SUMMARY

CISSP-certified infrastructure and cloud leader with over 11 years across UAE and India. I lead enterprise infrastructure, cloud and cybersecurity engineering functions: setting the strategy, transforming legacy environments into cloud-native and hybrid platforms, and putting in the operating model, automation and resilience to run them at scale. My cybersecurity strengths are technical and hands-on, from network and endpoint security to identity, detection and response. I own architecture and vendor decisions, manage infrastructure cost, and build the teams behind delivery.

EXPERIENCE

Infrastructure and Cloud Lead | AEGI Holding Jun 2025 – Present
Abu Dhabi, UAE

- Lead the infrastructure, cloud and cybersecurity engineering function for a multi-entity holding group, setting technical strategy and standards across the business.
- Define enterprise infrastructure and cloud strategy, including a hybrid and multi-cloud direction across the major hyperscalers, and modernize legacy environments toward cloud-native platforms.
- Drive Infrastructure-as-Code and automation to accelerate deployment, improve consistency, and reduce manual operations.
- Run service delivery against ITIL-aligned incident, change and problem management, with monitoring, SLAs and continuous improvement.
- Own vendor selection, commercial evaluation and architecture decisions, manage infrastructure cost across on-premises and cloud, and develop investment cases for leadership.
- Build resilience through disaster recovery and business continuity planning, and establish security baselines across network, endpoint and identity layers.
- Define the capability roadmap and team structure for infrastructure and cloud, including future skills in automation and AI-enabled operations.
- Partner with executive leadership on infrastructure investment and strategic priorities.

Infrastructure Specialist | Abu Dhabi Chamber of Commerce Apr 2023 – May 2025
Abu Dhabi, UAE

- Led a cybersecurity engineering uplift across network, endpoint, identity and detection layers, raising the organization's security posture.
- Directed the data center modernization to hyperconverged infrastructure with minimal downtime, including compute, storage and network refresh.
- Standardized identity, access and device compliance, hardened endpoint security, and strengthened perimeter protection.
- Managed the infrastructure lifecycle across compute, storage and networking, and expanded cloud adoption to improve scalability and cost.
- Implemented monitoring and operational practices to improve uptime and performance across critical systems.

IT Infrastructure Engineer (onsite, Global Village) | Tech Mahindra LLC Mar 2022 – Apr 2023
Dubai, UAE

- Acted as client-facing technical lead for a large entertainment destination under a managed-services contract, continuing the data center, network and security program below.

IT Infrastructure Engineer | Global Village LLC Apr 2019 – Feb 2022
Dubai, UAE

- Owned end-to-end design, delivery and lifecycle management of the data center and network for a large-scale entertainment destination, including compute, storage and network infrastructure.
- Built the cybersecurity engineering capability for the site, covering network security, endpoint protection, access control and threat detection.

- Designed and managed enterprise LAN and WAN connectivity across multiple assets, with resilient network design, next-generation firewalls and network access control across 30+ distribution frames with full failover.
- Ran virtualization and platform optimization across 100+ virtual servers spanning on-premises and cloud, with disaster recovery and centralized backup.
- Established 24x7 monitoring, incident management and change control to keep critical systems available across the peak operating season.
- Managed multiple vendors and contractors across concurrent workstreams, including telecom and service partners.

Support Engineer, ICT & Cloud | EMTECH Computers LLC

Oct 2016 – Apr 2019

UAE

- Designed, implemented and maintained IT infrastructure across messaging, directory services and virtualization for multiple enterprise clients.
- Delivered server virtualization, high-availability clustering, and enterprise backup and disaster recovery.
- Led a 1,400-user enterprise email migration to Microsoft 365, including tenant-to-tenant consolidation.

Project Engineer | Gemini Communication

Jul 2015 – Jul 2016

India

Linux Network Administrator (Trainee) | IPSR IT Solutions

May 2014 – May 2015

India

SKILLS

Strategy & Transformation: Enterprise infrastructure & cloud strategy, Legacy modernization, Cloud-native & hybrid platforms, Digital transformation programs

Cloud & Platforms: Microsoft Azure, Multi-cloud & hybrid strategy (Azure, AWS, GCP), Cloud migration & optimization, Infrastructure-as-Code & automation, Hyperscaler partnerships

Cybersecurity Engineering: Network security & next-generation firewalls, Endpoint security & EDR/XDR, Identity & access management, Zero Trust, Email & web security, Vulnerability management, SIEM & threat detection, Security architecture & hardening

Operations & Service Excellence: ITIL-aligned service management, Incident, change & problem management, 24x7 monitoring, performance & uptime, SLAs, KPIs & continuous improvement

Commercial & FinOps: Infrastructure cost & TCO management, FinOps & cloud cost optimization, Business cases & ROI, Vendor & contract negotiation, Hyperscaler & telecom commercials

Network, Data Center & Resilience: Enterprise networking (LAN/WAN, SD-WAN), Data center & virtualization, Containerization & platform optimization, Disaster recovery & business continuity, Infrastructure lifecycle management

AI-Ready Infrastructure: AI-ready platform design, GPU & compute planning, Automation toward autonomous operations, AI governance & guardrails

Leadership: Team leadership & capability building, Organization & talent roadmap, Stakeholder & executive engagement, Vendor ecosystem management, Cross-functional collaboration

CERTIFICATIONS

- Certified Information Systems Security Professional (CISSP)
- Microsoft Certified Solutions Expert (MCSE): Cloud Platform and Infrastructure
- Microsoft Certified Solutions Associate (MCSA): Windows Server 2016
- Microsoft Azure Fundamentals (AZ-900)
- Microsoft Security, Compliance and Identity Fundamentals (SC-900)
- ITIL v4 Foundation (in progress)
- Cisco Certified Network Associate (CCNA) and Red Hat Certified Engineer (RHCE), 2014

EDUCATION

B.Tech, Electronics & Communication | University of Calicut, Kerala, India

2014

ADDITIONAL

- Nationality: Indian | Languages: English, Malayalam | UAE Driving License